

Consequences on the Whistleblower

Introduction

Whistleblowing is done to report serious wrongdoing, danger, fraud, or unethical activity in an organization. It may be ethically correct when public safety is at risk, but it can create serious problems for the person who reports it.

According to Fleddermann, whistleblowing is connected with the rights and responsibilities of engineers. Engineers have a duty to protect public health and safety, but whistleblowing is often seen by companies and coworkers as an act of disloyalty.

1. Loss of Job or Career Risk

The biggest consequence of whistleblowing is the risk of losing one's job. Employers may fire, demote, transfer, or ignore the whistleblower because they feel the employee has damaged the company.

Fleddermann explains that a whistleblower should think carefully because whistleblowing can put their career and family's financial security at risk. This is why whistleblowing should not be done for small issues.

2. Isolation from Coworkers

A whistleblower may become isolated inside the organization. Coworkers may stop trusting them or may think they betrayed the team.

Fleddermann says whistleblowing can create distrust, disharmony, and difficulty in teamwork. Even if the whistleblower is morally right, people inside the company may still see the action as disloyal.

3. Harassment and Retaliation

The whistleblower may face pressure, threats, harassment, or unfair treatment from management. They may be given less important work, removed from projects, or treated badly.

In the Challenger case, Roger Boisjoly gave evidence about the O-ring problem. After this, he was isolated in the company, his responsibilities were reduced, and he faced harassment from management. This shows how serious the personal consequences can become.

4. Damage to Reputation

Whistleblowing can damage the professional reputation of the engineer. Some people may respect the whistleblower as honest and brave, but others may label them as a troublemaker.

This can make it difficult to get promotions, references, or future jobs. Even when the whistleblower is protecting the public, their career may suffer because companies may fear hiring someone who reports internal problems.

5. Emotional and Mental Stress

Whistleblowing can create strong emotional pressure. The whistleblower may feel fear, guilt, anxiety, loneliness, or stress because the decision affects their job, family, coworkers, and company.

This is why Fleddermann says a whistleblower must understand their motives and reflect carefully before taking this step. Whistleblowing should be for public interest, not revenge or personal gain.

6. Legal and Financial Problems

Sometimes whistleblowing may lead to legal issues. The company may accuse the whistleblower of breaking confidentiality, damaging business reputation, or leaking private information.

The whistleblower may also need legal support, which can become expensive. Therefore, engineers should keep proper evidence, follow correct procedures, and report only serious matters.

7. Positive Consequences

Whistleblowing does not always have only negative results. It can prevent accidents, save lives, protect the public, stop fraud, and improve company practices.

If the whistleblower acts honestly and has strong evidence, they may also gain moral respect. Their action can force the organization to correct unsafe or unethical behavior.

How to Apply in Case Studies

In a case study, first write why the engineer blew the whistle. Then explain what consequences they may face.

Mention both sides:

- **Negative consequences:** job loss, isolation, harassment, reputation damage, stress, legal problems.
- **Positive consequences:** public safety, prevention of harm, correction of wrongdoing, moral respect.

Then conclude that whistleblowing is justified only when the issue is serious, evidence is strong, internal steps have failed, and public safety is at risk.

Memorization Checklist

Remember consequences with:

J-I-H-R-S-L-P

J — Job loss

I — Isolation

H — Harassment

R — Reputation damage

S — Stress

L — Legal/financial trouble

P — Public safety benefit

5-Mark Exam Answer

The consequences on a whistleblower can be serious. According to Fleddermann, engineers have a duty to protect public safety, but whistleblowing is often seen by companies and coworkers as disloyalty. Because of this, a whistleblower may face job loss, demotion, transfer, or damage to

career growth. They may also be isolated by coworkers because whistleblowing can create distrust and disharmony inside the organization.

A whistleblower may also face harassment, pressure from management, loss of responsibilities, and emotional stress. Their professional reputation may suffer because some people may call them a troublemaker, even if they acted ethically. There may also be legal or financial problems if the company claims that confidential information was leaked.

However, whistleblowing can also have positive results. It can prevent accidents, save lives, protect the public, and force an organization to correct wrongdoing. Therefore, whistleblowing should be done only when the matter is serious, evidence is strong, internal options have failed, and public safety or public interest is at risk.